

MAGIC WITH NO RULES

chaos magic

Developed in the UK in the late 1970s, chaos magic is an attempt to strip away the occult ritual, deep learning, and mysticism that surrounds ceremonial magic. There are no rules, dogma, or hierarchy, but there are goals of personal development, fulfillment, and a connection to the universe. The magic is described as “chaotic” in the sense that practitioners consider existence to be purely what an individual perceives it to be—change that perception, and the world changes as a result.

No-mind state

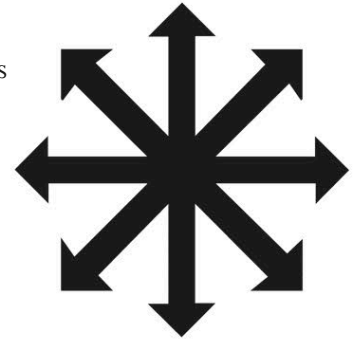
For chaos magic to work, an individual must first learn to free their subconscious—the store of great power, knowledge, and understanding. This idea was proposed by English painter and occultist Austin Osman Spare, whose 1913 work *The Book of Pleasure* became a core text. He claimed that freeing the subconscious could be achieved through a state of *gnosis*—putting the conscious mind in limbo to reach the subconscious mind. Spare suggested and used various techniques to

reach this trance-like state, including gentle, passive methods, such as yoga and meditative focus on a single point; and enjoyable activities, such as chanting, dancing, and sexual ecstasy (the most consistently favored), when the active mind is overtaken by pleasure.

Sigils—symbols of magical power

Spare also promoted the use of sigils—reducing the words and letters of a meaningful phrase to a monogram or glyph—believed to have magical power. Other magicians used sigils, too, as an aid to calling on external spirits, but Spare and other chaos magicians transmitted them internally to the subconscious when in a state of *gnosis*.

Vital to chaos magic is the ability to cast aside a belief or practice once a goal has been achieved. So as soon as a sigil had served its purpose, Spare advised deliberately forgetting it, an act of will that demanded exceptional discipline. In his world, a method could only be useful in the moment—if it became a habit, then it ceased to be chaos magic.



▲ Symbol of chaos

This symbol was devised in 1961 by English science-fiction writer, Michael Moorcock. In his own words, it “represents all possibilities,” as its eight arrows point in all directions.

“The more chaotic I am, the more complete I am.”

AUSTIN OSMAN SPARE, *THE BOOK OF PLEASURE*, 1913

IN CONTEXT

Spirit of chaos

Along with fellow English occultist Ray Sherwin, Peter Carroll was the driving force of chaos magic in the 1970s, influenced by Austin Osman Spare. Carroll cofounded the Illuminates of Thanateros, an international organization of practical magic and the most influential chaos magic grouping. His many magical and quasi-scientific ideas include a theory that time is three-dimensional and that starships capable of spanning the universe are a possibility.

Peter Carroll's *Liber Null and Psychonaut*, published in a single volume in 1987, are handbooks of the theory and practice of chaos magic.

